

Rating Area 1: Northwest Pennsylvania

Hub: Erie | Counties: Clarion, Crawford, Erie, Forest, McKean, Mercer, Venango, Warren

21.5% PID-approved avg. individual rate hike	102% avg. net premium increase, 2026	443,024 PA enrollees as of June 1, 2026	160,000+ cumulative PA terminations
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THE STATEWIDE PICTURE

The federal enhanced premium tax credits expired December 31, 2025, and Congress has not restored them; combined with the Pennsylvania Insurance Department's (PID) approved 21.5% average individual-market rate increase, Pennie reports the average net premium for the affected population rose 102% for 2026 (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025; Pennie, 2026a). Statewide, 85,000 people dropped Pennie coverage during Open Enrollment; as of June 1, 2026, cumulative cancellations exceed 160,000 and total enrollment stands at 443,024 (Pennie, 2026a, 2026b). Pennsylvania's own relief program, the Act 54 state subsidy, remains unfunded as the state budget missed its June 30, 2026 deadline for the fifth year running (Spotlight PA, 2026).

CARRIERS & RATES IN THIS AREA

This Lake Erie and Allegheny National Forest corridor is served primarily by Highmark and UPMC-affiliated plans, with Geisinger also active in several counties (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025b). As a moderate-competition rural-urban mix anchored by a single mid-sized city, plan choice narrows quickly outside the Erie metro area.

WATCH: NETWORK ADEQUACY OUTSIDE ERIE

Federal rules require routine primary-care and behavioral-health providers within 30 miles or 30 minutes of home. If a listed in-network provider outside the Erie metro area won't actually take new patients, that directory error — not the provider's true status — is what determines your rights: it's grounds to invoke the protections at right, not a reason to pay out-of-network rates.

YOUR CONSUMER PROTECTIONS

If a directory error sends you out-of-network: 28 Pa. Code § 9.725 caps your liability at in-network cost-sharing, and Act 252 of 2023 presumes an undisclosed out-of-network balance bill illegal. The federal IDR process (45 C.F.R. § 149.510) is a *provider-vs-plan* tool only — you cannot file one yourself; use the protections above instead.

Enroll / compare plans: pennie.com or 1-844-844-8040

Free legal help: phlp.org or 1-800-274-3258

File a complaint: pa.gov/consumer or 1-866-722-6675

Medicare counseling: PA MEDI 1-800-783-7067

SOURCES (APA)

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